

Rome Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** Italy
- **Language:** Italian (English spoken in tourist areas)
- **Currency:** Euro (EUR, €)
- **Time Zone:** Central European Time (CET, UTC+1; CEST UTC+2 in summer)
- **Emergency Number:** 112 (unified emergency number)
- **Dialing Code:** +39
- **Capital:** Rome is the capital of Italy
- **Population:** ~2.8 million (metropolitan area ~4.3 million)

Visa Requirements

Entry Rules by Nationality

Rome is part of Italy, which is in the **Schengen Area**. Visa requirements depend on your nationality:

- **US Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism/business up to **90 days within any 180-day period**
- **UK Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism/business up to **90 days within any 180-day period** (post-Brexit)
- **Canadian Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism/business up to **90 days within any 180-day period**
- **Australian Citizens:** Visa-free for tourism/business up to **90 days within any 180-day period**
- **EU/EEA Citizens:** No visa required, freedom of movement
- **Other Nationals:** Check [Schengen visa requirements](#)

Important Requirements

- **Passport Validity:** Must be valid for at least **3 months beyond your planned departure** from the Schengen area
- **Proof of Accommodation:** May be requested at immigration
- **Return Ticket:** May be requested to demonstrate intention to leave
- **Travel Insurance:** Recommended (required for some visa categories)

- **Sufficient Funds:** May need to demonstrate financial means (~€50-70 per day)

ETIAS (Starting 2025)

Even visa-exempt travelers will need **ETIAS authorization** before travel to Schengen countries. Apply online before departure.

Best Time to Visit

Spring (April - May)

- **Weather:** Mild and pleasant (15-22°C / 59-72°F)
- **Pros:** Perfect weather, flowers blooming, Easter celebrations, fewer crowds than summer
- **Cons:** Easter week can be very crowded, occasional rain
- **Best for:** Sightseeing, walking tours, outdoor dining

Summer (June - August)

- **Weather:** Hot and sunny (25-35°C / 77-95°F)
- **Pros:** Long days, lively atmosphere, outdoor events and concerts
- **Cons:** Very hot (especially July-August), extremely crowded, higher prices, many locals on vacation in August
- **Best for:** Those who love heat, evening activities, rooftop bars

Fall (September - October)

- **Weather:** Excellent (18-26°C / 64-79°F in September, cooling to 13-20°C in October)
- **Pros:** Great weather, wine harvest season, fewer tourists than summer, cultural events
- **Cons:** Can be rainy in late October, some restaurants close for holidays
- **Best for:** Wine lovers, food tours, comfortable sightseeing

Winter (November - February)

- **Weather:** Mild but can be rainy (8-15°C / 46-59°F)
- **Pros:** Very few tourists, lower prices, authentic local experience, Christmas decorations
- **Cons:** Shorter days, some rain, cooler temperatures, some sites have reduced hours
- **Best for:** Budget travelers, museum lovers, avoiding crowds

Peak Season: April-June, September-October **Shoulder Season:** March, November **Off Season:** December-February (except Christmas/New Year)

Top Attractions

Attraction	Area	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit	Advance Booking
Colosseum	Ancient Rome	€18 (combined with Forum & Palatine)	9:00-19:00 (varies by season)	Early morning or late afternoon	Required
Vatican Museums & Sistine Chapel	Vatican	€20 (€8 last Sunday of month)	Mon-Sat 9:00-18:00, last Sun free	Wednesday (Pope's audience day - fewer crowds)	Highly recommended
St. Peter's Basilica	Vatican	Free (dome: €10)	7:00-19:00 (summer), 7:00-18:30 (winter)	Early morning before crowds	No (but expect lines)
Roman Forum & Palatine Hill	Ancient Rome	€18 (combined with Colosseum)	9:00-19:00 (varies by season)	Morning after visiting Colosseum	Included with Colosseum ticket
Pantheon	Centro Storico	Free	Mon-Sat 9:00-19:00, Sun 9:00-18:00	Early morning	No
Trevi Fountain	Trevi	Free	24/7	Early morning or late evening	No
Spanish Steps	Spagna	Free	24/7	Sunrise or early morning	No
Piazza Navona	Centro Storico	Free	24/7	Evening for atmosphere	No
Borghese Gallery	Villa Borghese	€20	Tue-Sun 9:00-19:00	Any time slot	Required (2-hour time slots)
Castel Sant'Angelo	Borgo	€15	Tue-Sun 9:00-19:30	Late afternoon for sunset views	Recommended for summer
Trastevere Neighborhood	Trastevere	Free	N/A	Evening for dining and atmosphere	No
		Free			No

Attraction	Area	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit	Advance Booking
Campo de' Fiori Market	Centro Storico		Mon-Sat 7:00-14:00	Morning for fresh produce	

Insider Tips

- **Roma Pass:** 72-hour pass (€52) includes free entry to first 2 sites + unlimited public transport + discounts
- **Skip-the-Line Tours:** Worth it for Colosseum and Vatican Museums during peak season
- **Dress Code:** Modest dress required for Vatican (covered shoulders and knees)
- **Free Sundays:** Vatican Museums free on last Sunday of the month (expect huge crowds)

Neighborhoods & Districts

Centro Storico (Historic Center)

- **Character:** Heart of ancient and Renaissance Rome, pedestrian-friendly maze of piazzas
- **Must-See:** Pantheon, Piazza Navona, Campo de' Fiori, Trevi Fountain
- **Food:** Traditional Roman trattorias, gelaterias, cafes
- **Transport:** Mostly walkable, nearest metro: Spagna, Barberini
- **Stay Here If:** You want to be in the middle of everything

Trastevere

- **Character:** Bohemian neighborhood with cobblestone streets, artisan workshops, vibrant nightlife
- **Must-See:** Santa Maria in Trastevere church, local trattorias, street artists
- **Food:** Authentic Roman cuisine, aperitivo bars, artisan pizza
- **Transport:** Tram 8, bus H from Termini
- **Stay Here If:** You want authentic local atmosphere and great dining

Vatican & Prati

- **Character:** Upscale residential area near Vatican City, elegant streets
- **Must-See:** Vatican Museums, St. Peter's Basilica, Castel Sant'Angelo
- **Food:** High-end restaurants, local markets, quality trattorias

- **Transport:** Metro A (Ottaviano, Cipro)
- **Stay Here If:** You want quieter area near Vatican, good value hotels

Testaccio

- **Character:** Working-class neighborhood turned foodie haven, authentic and unpretentious
- **Must-See:** Testaccio Market, Protestant Cemetery, Monte Testaccio nightlife
- **Food:** Traditional Roman offal dishes, food market, aperitivo culture
- **Transport:** Metro B (Piramide), tram 3
- **Stay Here If:** You're a food lover seeking authentic Rome

Monti

- **Character:** Hipster neighborhood with vintage shops, craft beer bars, creative vibe
- **Must-See:** Monti district streets, boutique shopping, Colosseum nearby
- **Food:** Trendy restaurants, wine bars, international cuisine
- **Transport:** Metro B (Cavour, Colosseo)
- **Stay Here If:** You want trendy atmosphere near ancient sites

Aventine Hill

- **Character:** Quiet, upscale residential area with stunning views and gardens
- **Must-See:** Keyhole view of St. Peter's (Knights of Malta), Orange Garden (Giardino degli Aranci)
- **Food:** Limited restaurants, more residential
- **Transport:** Metro B (Circo Massimo)
- **Visit For:** Peaceful escape, romantic sunset views

Food & Dining

Signature Roman Dishes

- **Cacio e Pepe:** Pasta with pecorino cheese and black pepper (deceptively simple, hard to perfect)
- **Carbonara:** Pasta with guanciale (cured pork jowl), egg, pecorino, black pepper (NO CREAM!)
- **Amatriciana:** Pasta with guanciale, tomato, pecorino
- **Gricia:** Pasta with guanciale and pecorino (like carbonara without egg)

- **Saltimbocca alla Romana:** Veal with prosciutto and sage
- **Carciofi alla Romana:** Roman-style artichokes
- **Suppli:** Fried rice balls with mozzarella (Roman version of arancini)
- **Pizza al Taglio:** Pizza by the slice, sold by weight
- **Porchetta:** Roasted pork with herbs

Dining Customs

- **Coffee Culture:**
 - Cappuccino ONLY for breakfast (never after 11am!)
 - Espresso after meals, standing at the bar
 - Sitting at table costs more than standing at bar
- **Meal Times:**
 - Lunch: 12:30-15:00 (many places close after)
 - Dinner: 19:30-23:00 (restaurants open around 19:00)
 - Avoid tourist trap restaurants serving "all day"
- **Coperto:** Cover charge (€1-3 per person) for bread and table service - normal practice
- **Tipping:** Service often included; round up or leave 5-10% for exceptional service
- **Water:** Ask for "acqua del rubinetto" (tap water, free) or bottled water (€2-4)

Where to Eat

- **Avoid:** Restaurants with picture menus, aggressive touts, those right on major tourist squares
- **Seek:** Trattorias where locals eat, no English menu (good sign!), daily specials on chalkboard
- **Price Guide:**
 - Budget meal: €10-15 (pizza al taglio, trattoria)
 - Mid-range: €25-40 per person
 - Fine dining: €60+ per person

Aperitivo Culture

- **What:** Pre-dinner drinks (18:00-21:00) with complimentary snacks/buffet
- **Price:** €8-12 for drink + food
- **Where:** Bars in Trastevere, Monti, Testaccio
- **Tip:** Can substitute for dinner on a budget

Transportation

From the Airports

Fiumicino (FCO) - Leonardo da Vinci Airport

- **Leonardo Express Train:** Direct to Termini station (32 min, €14, every 15-30 min, 6:23-23:23)
- **FL1 Regional Train:** To Trastevere, Ostiense, Tiburtina (slower, stops at multiple stations, €8)
- **Bus:** Terravision/SIT to Termini (55 min, €6-7)
- **Taxi:** Fixed rate €48 to within Aurelian Walls, €55-60 outside, 45-60 min
- **Uber/Private Transfer:** Similar to taxi prices

Ciampino (CIA) Airport

- **Bus:** Terravision/SIT to Termini (40 min, €6)
- **Bus + Metro:** Local bus to Ciampino station, then train to Termini (cheaper but slower)
- **Taxi:** Fixed rate €30 to within Aurelian Walls, 30-40 min

Public Transportation

Metro (Subway)

- **Lines:** Line A (orange), Line B (blue), Line C (green, limited)
- **Coverage:** Limited compared to other capitals, doesn't reach many tourist sites
- **Hours:** 5:30-23:30 (Fri-Sat until 1:30)
- **Tickets:** Single ride €1.50 (100 min), day pass €7, 3-day €18
- **Key Stops:** Termini (hub), Spagna (Spanish Steps), Colosseo, Ottaviano (Vatican)

Buses & Trams

- **Coverage:** Extensive network, reaches areas metro doesn't
- **Frequency:** Can be unreliable, check Google Maps for real-time
- **Night Buses:** After metro closes
- **Same Tickets:** Use same tickets as metro
- **Tip:** Confusing for tourists, but necessary for some destinations

Walking

- **Best Option:** Rome's historic center is compact and walkable

- **Challenges:** Cobblestones (wear comfortable shoes), traffic doesn't always stop for pedestrians
- **Recommended:** Walk as much as possible, use public transport for longer distances

Taxis & Ride-Sharing

- **Official Taxis:** White with taxi sign, metered (starting fare €3 weekday day, €4.50 night/Sunday)
- **Where to Find:** Taxi stands (not hailed on street), call radio taxi
- **Apps:** FreeNow (mytaxi), iTaxi
- **Uber:** Available but limited (UberBlack only, similar price to taxi)
- **Warning:** Avoid unlicensed taxis at airports/stations

Roma Pass

- **72 Hours (€52):** First 2 attractions free, then discounts + unlimited public transport
- **48 Hours (€32):** First attraction free, then discounts + unlimited public transport
- **Worth It If:** Visiting 2+ major paid attractions + using public transport extensively

Cultural Tips & Customs

Dress & Appearance

- **Religious Sites:** Covered shoulders and knees required (Vatican, churches)
- **Bring a Scarf:** Women can cover shoulders quickly when entering churches
- **Romans Dress Well:** Smart casual is the norm, avoid beach/gym wear in city
- **Fare Bella Figura:** "Making a good impression" is important - dress presentably

Social Customs

- **Greetings:** Handshake or kiss on both cheeks (friends/family)
- **Afternoon Riposo:** Many shops close 13:00-16:00 for siesta (less common in tourist areas)
- **Evening Passeggiata:** Evening stroll before dinner, social ritual
- **Slower Pace:** Don't rush meals or conversations, Romans take their time
- **Speaking Italian:** Learn basic phrases - locals appreciate the effort

Dining Etiquette

- **No Cappuccino After Meals:** Considered a breakfast drink only
- **Break Bread, Don't Cut:** Tear bread with hands, don't use knife
- **Pasta Course First:** Traditional meal: antipasto, primo (pasta), secondo (meat/fish), dolce (dessert)
- **Don't Ask for Changes:** Chefs prepare dishes traditionally, customization frowned upon
- **When in Rome:** Follow local customs - if locals are eating pizza with hands, do the same

Do's and Don'ts

DO: - Validate your public transport ticket (or face €100 fine) - Keep right on escalators - Dress modestly for churches - Learn basic Italian phrases - Take your time and enjoy the pace

DON'T: - Sit on monument steps (illegal, can be fined) - Eat/drink near fountains (Trevi Fountain especially - €500 fine) - Touch artifacts or artwork - Feed pigeons - Assume everyone speaks English (try Italian first)

Language Tips

- **Buongiorno:** Good morning/day (formal greeting)
- **Buonasera:** Good evening (after ~2pm)
- **Per favore:** Please
- **Grazie:** Thank you
- **Scusi:** Excuse me
- **Parla inglese?:** Do you speak English?
- **Il conto, per favore:** The bill, please

Safety & Health

Safety Overview

Rome is generally safe for tourists, but pickpocketing and petty theft are common in tourist areas.

Areas to Watch

- **Termini Station:** Hub for pickpockets and scammers
- **Metro Lines A & B:** Crowded trains attract pickpockets
- **Colosseum/Forum Area:** Watch bags and pockets

- **Trevi Fountain:** Very crowded, prime pickpocket location
- **Buses:** Especially crowded buses (40, 64 to Vatican)

Common Scams

- **Fake Petition Scam:** Women ask you to sign petition, then demand "donation" while accomplice steals from bag
- **Bracelet Scam:** Someone ties bracelet on wrist, then demands payment
- **Gladiator Photos:** Costumed men at Colosseum demand €20+ for photos
- **Restaurant Menus:** Some switch menus after you order (bring different bill)
- **Taxi Scams:** Unlicensed taxis at airports, "broken" meters
- **ATM Helpers:** Strangers offering to help at ATMs (decline)

Safety Tips

- **Bags:** Crossbody bags in front, not backpacks in crowds
- **Valuables:** Don't carry more than needed, use hotel safe
- **Phone:** Be alert when using phone on street (snatch theft on scooters)
- **Stay Aware:** Especially in crowded areas and on public transport
- **Cobblestones:** Wear sturdy shoes with good ankle support

Health & Medical

- **Emergency:** 112 (all emergencies)
- **Pharmacies:** Green cross sign, can advise on minor ailments
- **Prescription Drugs:** Bring sufficient supply + prescription
- **EU Health Card:** EU citizens should bring European Health Insurance Card
- **Travel Insurance:** Non-EU visitors should have comprehensive travel insurance
- **Tap Water:** Safe to drink from taps and public fountains (nasoni)
- **Drinking Fountains:** Nasoni fountains throughout city have drinkable water (free!)
- **Heat:** Stay hydrated in summer, use sunscreen, take breaks in heat

Emergency Numbers

- **General Emergency:** 112
- **Police:** 113
- **Medical Emergency:** 118
- **Fire:** 115

- **Embassy/Consulate:** Keep your country's contact info

Practical Information

Electricity

- **Voltage:** 230V, 50Hz
- **Plug Types:** Type C (2-pin), Type F (2-pin), Type L (3-pin Italian)
- **Adapter Needed:** Most countries need adapter
- **Where to Buy:** Airports, electronics shops, some hotels provide

Money & Banking

- **Currency:** Euro (EUR, €)
- **ATMs:** Widely available, best exchange rates
- **Credit Cards:** Visa/Mastercard widely accepted, American Express less so
- **Cash:** Still preferred at small shops, markets, cafes
- **Daily Budget:** Budget €60-80, mid-range €120-180, luxury €300+
- **Tipping:** Not mandatory but appreciated - round up or 5-10%

Pharmacies (Farmacia)

- **Marked By:** Green cross sign
- **Services:** Over-the-counter medication, basic health advice
- **After Hours:** Rotating 24-hour pharmacies (list posted on each pharmacy)
- **Prescription:** Some medications available without prescription that require one elsewhere

August Closures (Ferragosto)

- **When:** Mid-August (especially around August 15)
- **What Closes:** Many family-owned restaurants, some shops
- **What Stays Open:** Major tourist attractions, hotels, restaurants in tourist areas
- **Plan Ahead:** Check opening hours if visiting mid-August

Business Hours

- **Shops:** Mon-Sat 9:00/10:00 - 13:00, 15:30/16:00 - 19:30/20:00
- **Sunday:** Many shops closed (tourist areas often open)

- **Restaurants:** Lunch 12:30-15:00, dinner 19:30-23:00
- **Museums:** Vary, often closed Mondays
- **Churches:** Often close 12:00-15:00 for siesta

Internet & Communication

- **SIM Cards:** Available at airports, tobacco shops (tabacchi), phone stores
- **Providers:** TIM, Vodafone, Wind Tre
- **Tourist SIMs:** €15-25 for 2-4 weeks with data
- **Free WiFi:** Common in hotels, cafes, some piazzas (Roma WiFi network)

Useful Apps

- **Transport:** Google Maps, Moovit, Roma Mobilità
- **Food:** TheFork (restaurant reservations/discounts), Tripadvisor
- **Translation:** Google Translate (download Italian offline)
- **Taxis:** FreeNow (mytaxi), iTaxi

Public Toilets

- **Limited:** Not many free public toilets
- **Options:** Cafes/bars (order espresso €1), department stores, museums
- **McDonald's:** Reliable option with bathrooms
- **Tip:** Use bathroom at attractions before leaving

Shopping

- **Markets:** Campo de' Fiori (morning, daily except Sunday), Porta Portese (Sunday flea market)
- **Shopping Streets:** Via del Corso, Via Condotti (luxury)
- **Department Stores:** Rinascente, Coin
- **VAT Refund:** Non-EU residents can claim VAT back (minimum €154.94 purchase)

Travel Responsibly: Rome is a living city and UNESCO World Heritage site. Respect monuments, follow rules, support local businesses, and help preserve this incredible city for future generations.

Pro Tip: The best way to experience Rome is to wander. Get lost in the narrow streets, stumble upon hidden piazzas, and let the city reveal itself to you. Some of the most magical moments happen when you're not following a guidebook.